



▲ SITTING TIGHT

Where food is plentiful because the water is rich in nutrients, marine creatures can make a good living by staying in one place and collecting any food that comes their way. Many animals, like these mussels, attach themselves to rocks and other solid objects, while others burrow into soft sand or mud, and extend feeding tubes or long tentacles to gather food.

LIVING UNDERWATER

Living underwater is unlike living on land, because the moving water is full of drifting food. A huge variety of animals such as sea anemones, barnacles, and clams make the most of this by anchoring themselves in one place and waiting for the currents to bring food to them. More mobile animals actively search for food, but even these benefit from the way the water supports their bodies. Many are superbly streamlined, enabling them to swim efficiently, and some of their highly tuned senses work in ways that we find hard to imagine.



GATHERING FOOD



FILTERING

A mussel draws water into its body through a siphon tube, filters it for edible particles, then expels it through a second siphon. Clams that burrow in soft sand feed in the same way.



STRAINING

Some marine worms spread fans of tentacles in the water to snare any edible items. Barnacles use a similar technique, extending feathery legs from "trapdoors" in the tops of their shells.



TRAPPING

The tentacles of some animals like this anemone are armed with tiny stings, which they use to immobilize and trap small animals. Venomous jellyfish use the same adaptation in open water.



SEIZING

Tropical garden eels sit with their tails in the sand and their mouths facing the current, ready to seize any food items that drift by. They live only in places where the current is quite strong.